One way populists infiltrate IOs is by staffing them with representatives who resist or actively undermine IOs' missions. For example, countries with poor human-rights records have placed delegates in human-rights organizations, turning watchdogs into lapdogs and diluting their ability to promote global accountability (Hafner-Burton 2012). Similarly, intelligence agencies have leveraged IOs to gain access to sensitive information. The Soviet Union famously exploited its position at the UN to gather intelligence on the United States, while more recently China and Russia have been accused of leveraging their access to the EU and NATO headquarters to obtain confidential data (Bosco 2012). Former Polish prime minister Mateusz Morawiecki has similarly espoused a desire to join forces with other far-right parties across Europe in his role as president of the European Conservatives and Reformists as a means of enforcing a more right-wing agenda in the EU.[4]

Populists also exploit IOs' rules and procedures to their advantage. While IOs often include escape clauses or exemptions for extraordinary circumstances, populists may misuse these loopholes during routine periods to sidestep organizational constraints. For example, Donald Trump in his first term invoked a national security exception under WTO rules to impose higher tariffs, a move that many feared would set a dangerous precedent for other members to follow suit.[5] This type of strategic rule-bending undermines trust in IO governance and encourages other states to defect as well, destabilizing the global rules-based order.

Another form of co-optation occurs when populists install allies at the helm of IOs to align their agendas with national interests. Donald Trump's appointment of David Malpass as president of the World Bank raised concerns about the institution's independence. Malpass, a vocal critic of multilateralism, sought to limit interest-generating loans to middle-income states like China and India. He also deprioritized climate change initiatives, scaling back on essential projects and staffing that could have advanced global environmental goals.[6] This pattern of behavior is not isolated; populists like Hungary's Viktor Orbán have used similar tactics to nudge institutions like the European Union in illiberal directions.

While larger powers have the resources and influence to co-opt IOs, even smaller states can find ways to punch above their weight. Institutional features like rotating leadership positions or rules that make smaller states